

File 11_15_52.UFO
date August 13, 1988

Air Force Jet is Circled by Silver
Sphere at Very High Speed

Date of Sighting: November 15, 1952
Location: Pyongyang, North Korea
38 deg 45' N; 126 deg E
Time: 1345Z to 1352Z
Number of Obs. 2
Number of UFOs: 1
Duration: 5 to 7 minutes
Class: UM

Synopsis:

The following synopsis is taken from the Air Force Intelligence Information Report No. 52-350 dated 28 November 1952 prepared by 1st Lt. James Power of the 6149th Tactical Control Squadron. It was approved by Col. John V. Hearn, Jr., Director of Intelligence. Page 1 of 4 is the cover page.

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"On 15 November 1952, 1st Lt. Layton S. Bass, and 1st Lt. Richard I. Barnard, USAF of the 6149th Tac Con Sq, 6147th Tactical Control Group, were interviewed with regard to the sighting of an unidentified flying object.

"At 1345I, 15 November 1952, Lt. Bass, pilot, and Lt. Barnard, observer, were flying a combat mission in a T-6 aircraft over the central sector of the friendly main line of resistance. At the time cited, Lt. Bass was flying in the vicinity of CT795418 at 130 miles per hour indicated air speed, 10,500 feet, indicated altitude and in a northerly direction. The weather conditions were clear, with visibility from 15 to 20 miles. The sun at this time of day is in a south, southwesterly position from the incident area. Winds at 10,000 feet were generally from 240 degrees with velocities up to 20 miles per hour.

"Lt. Bass first noted the unidentified object moving north, apparently close to the terrain. The sighting (points #1 on attached map overlay) was originally made against the slope of Osang-San (Papa-San) at CT654455. The object, initially dismissed by Lt. Bass as an aircraft, moved north approximately five (5) miles and then turned south and gained altitude. At the same time the T-6 aircraft, was orbiting "Ash can Control" awaiting the arrival of fighter bombers which they were to control in a strike. When the T-6 aircraft was at point #2 as indicated in the map overlay, Lt. Bass again sighted the object

and identified it as not being an aircraft. This sighting was to the right of the T-6, at an estimated 100-200 yards. Lt. Bass described it as spherical in shape, silver in color and approximately 8-10 feet in diameter. He further described the object as lacking any visible (sic), means of propulsion and having no protrusions of any sort. The surface was smooth. There was no audible sound.

"When Lt. Bass saw the object, which was moving at approximately the same speed as the aircraft, he turned the aircraft towards it slightly at which time the object headed south and began climbing at a high rate of speed, turning into a left orbit around the aircraft. Lt. Bass called the object to the attention of Lt. Barnard who saw it as it went into its left hand orbit.

"He first saw the object at the ten o'clock level position. Lt. Barnard differs with the pilot on one point, as to distance, in that he estimates the minimum distance of sighting to be from 500 to 1,000 yards, (Closer to the latter).

"In explanation for the difference between the estimates of minimum distance of the sighting, Lt. Barnard suggests that he did not see the object till it was to the left of the aircraft and that the pilot initially observed it at the same altitude when the object was to the right of the aircraft.

"Lt. Barnard's description of the object was that it was a silver spherical object, approximately the size of a man's thumb nail held at extended arms length. He further described the object as "shimmering" and having a "halo" which surrounded the object. The halo was only of hairline thickness. He further stated that the shimmering effect appeared to be more apparent when the object was between the aircraft and the general direction of the sun. The object appeared to Lt. Barnard as being darker at the edges, as a translucent sphere would appear when held up to a light.

"That the object was turning in a left hand orbit about a central point, with the aircraft flying a tighter circle within the path of the object, was confirmed by both sources. The diameter of the circle marked by the object in its path appeared to increase as it moved. After the first complete circle the object began to climb more rapidly and continued increasing the radius of its circle.

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"The altitude and full description of the object and its actions were described by the pilot, by radio to "Mosquito Godfrey" a ground control, during the sighting.

"The object circling three times to the left in a diameter ranging from 100 to 1000 yards gained considerable altitude, and then moved off at what both men estimated to be 500 to 800 miles per hour in a south westerly direction towards the sun. Lt. Bass estimated the object was at approximately 18,000 feet when it was lost by both observers in the glare near the sun. Lt. Bass made the entire observation with the naked eye. Lt. Barnard wore government issue greenish brown glasses.

"No optical device was used. The entire sighting extended over a period of 5 to 7 minutes, from 1345I to 1352I. The object was viewed against various colored backgrounds, the dark terrain, and blue sky and white clouds. It remained constant as to shape, size, and color.

"Both sources state that the general motion of the object was steady and gave the impression of controlled flight. They stated that it did not appear to be moving on the motion of air current.

"The pilot had flown 54 missions in this theater and the observer had flown 48 missions.

"Statements were obtained and are attached to this report... (remainder of paragraph deleted intentionally).

"COMMENTS OF THE PREPARING OFFICER

"1. Both sources are considered to be competent (sic) observers and sightings reported by them are considered reliable. Both officers gave exact information and during the interview were certain on all points of the observation. Lt. Barnard, gave considerable detail in his debriefing which is reflected in the extensive statement that he supplied to supplement this report.

"2. During the inquiry conducted by the investigating officer, Lt. Bass indicated verbally that during his radio contact with Mosquito Godfrey, they reported that no other object besides their aircraft was picked up by the radar covering that sector.

"3. Lt. Col Andrew Payton, Operations Officer, 30th Weather Squadron was contacted. He stated that the only weather station maintained by the Air Force in that area was at Chip'o-1 CT5222, however the largest weather balloon utilized by this unit is a 30 gram "ceiling" balloon with a maximum (sic) inflated size of 15 in. diameter. He further stated that there was little possibility of a weather balloon of any size performing as the object is reported doing under the prevailing conditions.

"4. At Tokehong, Korea, C33089, approximately south west of the area in which the object was sighted, the 1st Artillery Observation Battalion, an army light plane unit, maintains a

meteorological station. The officer in charge, Warrant Officer, Larry Reddan stated that at 1257I on 15 November, 350 area, a balloon was released.

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"It was a natural latex (white) color. The rate of ascent on this size balloon is approximately 1200 feet per minute. Major Decker of the Headquarters, Fifth Air Force, Weather Station, stated upon questioning, that at 10,000 feet a 350 gram balloon should maintain an approximate spherical shape unless one part of the balloon was weaker and should therefore bulge.

"5. It is possible that the unidentified object could have been this 350 gram balloon."

signed
JOHN H. CUMMING
Major, USAF
Commanding

D/I FEAF Comments

"1. The 350 gram balloon released 50 minutes previous to the sighting would not be expected to be at any visible altitude at the time of the incident unless it were leaking, (which would preclude the rapid climb described).

"2. There have previously been a number of unidentified sightings in the CF and DF grid of Korea. Of these, at least 5 sightings have tentatively been identified as enemy balloons.

"3. Vectoring an aircraft on a free balloon is actually difficult, and false impressions of rapid movement can easily be made. From the available information it appears that the object was probably a balloon, and possibly one launched by frontline enemy troops."

Signed

CHARLES T. DAW???

Brigadier General, USAF
Deputy for Intelligence

Note: In addition to the above intelligence report this file contained one sketch of the ufo presented here as figure 1 and a drawing showing the approximate flight paths of the airplane and the ufo, figure 2. There was also a two page memo by Major Francis C. Haney, Intelligence Officer, 6147th Tactical Control Group, APO 970 dated 18 November 1952 to the Director of Intelligence, Fifth Air Force (Adv.), APO 970. This memo summarized the basic events cited above and did not include any

new information. The one page statement signed and dated 18 November 1952 by pilot L. S. Bass and a four page statement signed and dated 19 November 1952 by flight observer R. I. Barnard also were included in this file.

Comments:

This official U. S. Air Force case is notable for several reasons. First, the two eye witnesses were deemed both experienced and credible and had an excellent vantage point from which to make their observations. They viewed the object through 360 degrees of azimuth which afforded them a wide perspective of sun and shadow angles. Second, the sun would have been XX degrees altitude above the horizon and YYY degrees from true north. There is no possibility that this darker object could have been a solar reflection off the canopy of the airplane. The Air Force's contention that the ufo was a meteorological balloon deserves further examination.

There are several good arguments against the balloon explanation. The first is its 180 degree change of course when near the ground (see points 1 and 2 in Figure 2). Second is the stated fact that it appeared to remain near the surface of the earth for about five miles before gaining in altitude. Three, Lt. Bass watched the object climb at an estimated 500 to 700 mph before it started orbiting. As noted above by Major Cumming, the usual climb rate of a small balloon such as this is about 1,200 feet per minute or only 13.6 mph. This is a factor of over fifty times slower than the pilot's estimate of its speed. The fourth point has to do with the effect of wind.

With winds at about 20 mph from 240 degrees azimuth at 10,000 feet altitude with the airplane also flying at about 10,000 feet, a free flying balloon would be expected to travel about 1.6 miles in the same direction in five minutes. For an airplane flying at 130 mph in a high wing left-hand bank, one complete orbit of 360 degrees would require about tbd seconds. For the ufo to have been a balloon flying along an upward-rising linear trajectory would require the T-6 to orbit about it in a generally elliptically shaped flight path rather than the circular flight path shown in Figure 2.

The final fact which suggests that the object was not a balloon is its discription. Lt. Barnard stated the following: "It was a silvery, shimmering, apparently perfectly spherical object, with a slight halo or corona. This halo was not thick in comparison to the diameter of the object, being a mere hairline in apparent thickness, a sort of hazy radiance, which did not, however, in any way or at any point blur or mar the hard, sharp outline of the sphere's circumference."

The airplane's observer continued, "The sphere itself was

rather darker around the periphery than at the center, as a globe of translucent substance will appear when silhouetted against a source of light. However, at no time during the sighting was the object actually in direct line between us and the sun, and there was no other conceivable source of light at the time. The surface of the sphere appeared to glint or shimmer, as if with reflected light. However, this shimmering appearance was, if anything, somewhat **more** apparent when the object was between us and the general direction of the sun, when resumabably the surface presented to our view would be shadowed, than it was when we were looking at it with the sun at our backs. The word "translucent" flashed into my mind spontaneously almost immediately upon sighting it."

Lt. Barnard also stated. "I have also considered the possibility of light reflection phenomena, although not a graduate phycist (sic), I am familiar with the general principles of optics, and unless it can be scientifically proved otherwise, I refuse flatly to believe that any light refraction phenomenon can present such uniformity and definiteness in its appearance from such a tremendous variety of ranges, altitudes, angles of inspection, and optical conditions, nor that its motion over such a period of time (5 to 7 minutes) could continually be so smooth and regular and lend itself so readily to an obvious theory of purposeful action."